

Motivational Interviewing

Learner guide | SWP-008 | School of Substance Use & Addiction Recovery

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Motivational Interviewing. By the end of the course, you should be able to use the spirit and core communication skills of motivational interviewing in appropriate settings.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Use the spirit and core communication skills of motivational interviewing in appropriate settings.
- Apply the key ideas from MI spirit.
- Apply the key ideas from OARS skills.
- Apply the key ideas from Planning change.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. MI spirit	partnership, acceptance, compassion, evocation, autonomy, and avoiding the righting reflex	10 to 15 minutes
2. OARS skills	open questions, affirmations, reflections, summaries, and listening for change talk	10 to 15 minutes
3. Planning change	responding to ambivalence, eliciting commitment language, goal setting, and referral	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 MI spirit

This module focuses on partnership, acceptance, compassion, evocation, autonomy, and avoiding the righting reflex. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Partnership
- Acceptance
- Compassion
- Evocation
- Autonomy
- Avoiding the righting reflex

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of mi spirit in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of partnership, acceptance, compassion, evocation, autonomy, and avoiding the righting reflex. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through mi spirit safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 OARS skills

This module focuses on open questions, affirmations, reflections, summaries, and listening for change talk. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Open questions
- Affirmations
- Reflections
- Summaries
- Listening for change talk

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of oars skills in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of open questions, affirmations, reflections, summaries, and listening for change talk. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through oars skills safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Planning change

This module focuses on responding to ambivalence, eliciting commitment language, goal setting, and referral. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Responding to ambivalence
- Eliciting commitment language
- Goal setting
- Referral

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of planning change in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of responding to ambivalence, eliciting commitment language, goal setting, and referral. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through planning change safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: MI spirit.
- Review the distinction between: OARS.
- Review the distinction between: change talk.
- Review the distinction between: responses to resistance.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.